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## EDITORIAL

### **Pope Francis' Teachings on Marriage and Family**

Pope Francis' pontificate marks a pivotal moment in the Catholic Church's engagement with marriage and sexuality, characterized by a reaffirmation of magisterial tradition amid a rapidly evolving secular landscape. Through his 2016 apostolic exhortation, *Amoris Laetitia*,<sup>1</sup> alongside homilies, interviews, and addresses, Francis articulates a vision rooted in the Church's doctrinal foundations while responding to contemporary realities.

The Second Vatican Council (1962–1965) redefined the Church's understanding of marriage, articulating its dual purpose as a unitive and procreative covenant (*Gaudium et Spes* §48-50). The council acknowledged the complexities of applying general norms to individual circumstances, setting the stage for a more nuanced approach to moral theology. This framework informed *Humanae Vitae*,<sup>2</sup> where Paul VI reiterated the Church's prohibition of artificial contraception, asserting that “each and every marital act must of necessity retain its intrinsic relationship to the procreation of human life” (HV §11). Issued during the secular upheavals of the sexual revolution, the rise of hormonal contraception, and feminist advocacy for reproductive autonomy, the encyclical sparked significant controversy, exposing divisions within the Church. Theologians and laity, influenced by secular individualism, called for greater emphasis on personal conscience, while traditionalists upheld the encyclical's moral clarity.<sup>3</sup> As Richard Gaillardetz observes, the polarized reception of *Humanae Vitae* complicated the assimilation of Vatican II's ecclesial vision, (like its teachings on the *sensus fidei* and episcopal collegiality),

providing a complex historical backdrop for Francis' interventions.<sup>4</sup>

John Paul II's 1981 *Familiaris Consortio*<sup>5</sup> reinforced HV's teachings, condemning contraception and upholding the indissolubility of marriage (FC §84). Benedict XVI continued this trajectory, unequivocally condemning contraception and emphasizing doctrinal clarity.<sup>6</sup>

Secular trends, including the sexual revolution, feminist movements, and the rise of diverse family structures, have profoundly influenced Pope Francis' approach. The sexual revolution challenged traditional norms, promoting individual autonomy in sexual and marital decisions. Feminist critiques questioned rigid gender roles, while the growing visibility of LGBTQ+ rights and non-traditional families, such as single-parent or patchwork households, demanded a reevaluation of pastoral care.<sup>7</sup> Francis responds by shifting from Pope John Paul II's "new evangelization," which focused on proclaiming doctrine, to a "pastoral conversion" that prioritizes engagement with individuals' lived experiences.<sup>8</sup> This shift is evident in Francis' emphasis on meeting people where they are. By acknowledging the complexities of modern family life, Francis seeks to bridge the gap between doctrine and the realities of diverse relationships, fostering a Church that is a "field hospital" responsive to human struggles.<sup>9</sup>

Francis' teachings on marriage, most comprehensively expressed in AL, reaffirm the Church's commitment to the indissolubility of marriage, declaring that the Church must not "desist from proposing the full ideal of marriage" (§307). This stance reflects continuity with the doctrinal legacy of GS and FC, which emphasized marriage's sacramental nature (FC §84). In a 2014 interview, Francis lauded Paul VI's "prophetic insight" in *Humanae Vitae* for resisting secular pressures toward contraception, and underscored the role of conscience in addressing individual circumstances.<sup>10</sup> This approach departs from the stricter moral absolutism of predecessors like John Paul II (FC §84),

offering a more flexible, pastoral framework that maintains doctrinal fidelity.

In his approach to sexuality, he upholds traditional teachings while engaging contemporary practices. AL reaffirms the intrinsic link between sexuality and procreation, echoing HV: “no genital act of husband and wife can refuse this meaning,<sup>86</sup> even when for various reasons it may not always in fact be get a new life.” (AL §301, HV §11f). However, he critiques an overemphasis on procreation that overshadows the relational dimension of conjugal love, responding to secular prioritizations of emotional intimacy and mutual support (AL §36). This nuanced perspective reflects the influence of post-modern ethical frameworks, which, since the 1960s, have elevated relational authenticity over reproductive imperatives.<sup>11</sup>

Francis’ treatment of sexual orientation signals a shift from earlier magisterial language. Departing from the language of “intrinsic disorder” in earlier magisterial documents,<sup>12</sup> he adopts a more inclusive rhetoric, famously stating in 2013, “Who am I to judge?” in response to questions about gay Catholics.<sup>13</sup> In a 2016 interview, he called for the Church to apologize to marginalized groups, including those identifying as LGBTQ, asserting, “The Church must say sorry for not having treated them with the respect they deserve.”<sup>14</sup> While upholding the Church’s teaching on marriage as a heterosexual sacrament, Francis’ rhetoric aligns with Vatican II’s call for dialogue with the modern world, though it has drawn criticism from traditionalists who perceive a risk to doctrinal coherence.<sup>15</sup>

Francis also engages with evolving gender dynamics. In *Amoris Laetitia*, he acknowledges that the significance of gender becomes less pronounced when addressing practical family challenges (AL §286), reflecting feminist critiques of rigid gender norms. This perspective responds to a world where gender fluidity and egalitarian ideals are increasingly prevalent, marking a subtle but significant evolution in the Church’s approach to gender roles.<sup>16</sup>

Pope Francis' teachings on marriage and sexuality constitute a significant development in Catholic moral theology, navigating the tension between historical tradition and contemporary realities. Rooted in the legacy of Vatican II and *Humanae Vitae*, his approach upholds the Church's doctrinal foundations while responding to shifts in family structures, gender norms, and sexual ethics. Though his approach has sparked both approbation and critique, it offers a theological framework that bridges tradition and modernity, aligning with the Church's mission to engage the world with compassion and fidelity (*Evangelii Gaudium* §49).

**Gigesh Meckal, TOR**

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<sup>1</sup> Hereafter AL.

<sup>2</sup> Hereafter HV.

<sup>3</sup> Charles E. Curran, "Humanae Vitae: Fifty Years Later," *Theological Studies* 79, no. 3 (2018): 520–540.

<sup>4</sup> Richard R. Gaillardetz, "Humanae Vitae and Its Ecclesial Consequences," *Theological Studies* 79, no. 4 (2018): 847–865.

<sup>5</sup> Hereafter FC.

<sup>6</sup> Benedict XVI, "Address to Participants of the International Congress Promoted by the Pontifical Lateran University on the 40th Anniversary of the Encyclical 'Humanae Vitae'" May 10, 2008, [https://w2.vatican.va/content/benedict-xvi/en/speeches/2008/may/documents/hf\\_ben-xvi\\_spe\\_20080510\\_humanae-vitae.html](https://w2.vatican.va/content/benedict-xvi/en/speeches/2008/may/documents/hf_ben-xvi_spe_20080510_humanae-vitae.html).

<sup>7</sup> Martin M. Lintner, "Divorce and Remarriage: A Reading of Amoris Laetitia from a Theological-Ethical Perspective," in *A Point of No Return? Amoris Laetitia on Marriage, Divorce and Remarriage*, edited by Thomas Knieps-Port le Roi, 126.

<sup>8</sup> Mieczysław Polak, "From Familiaris Consortio to Amoris Laetitia: Pope Francis' Renewed Vision of the Pastoral Care of Families," *Verbum Vitae* 40 (2022): 412..

<sup>9</sup> Richard R. Gaillardetz, "Humanae Vitae and Its Ecclesial Consequences," *Theological Studies* 79 (2018): 862.

- <sup>10</sup> “Transcript: Pope Francis' March 5 interview with Corriere della Sera,” March 5, 2014, Transcript: Pope Francis' March 5 interview with Corriere della Sera | Catholic News Agency.
- <sup>11</sup> Jacob Kohlhaas, “Constructing Parenthood: Catholic Teaching 1880 to the Present,” *Theological Studies* 79, no. 3 (2018): 617–635.
- <sup>12</sup> Congregation for the Doctrine of the Faith, *Letter to the Bishops of the Catholic Church on the Pastoral Care of Homosexual Persons*, October 1, 1986, Letter to the Bishops of the Catholic Church on the Pastoral Care of Homosexual Persons.
- <sup>13</sup> Antonio Spadaro, “A Big Heart Open to God: An Interview with Pope Francis,” *America*, September 19, 2013, A Big Heart Open to God: An interview with Pope Francis | America Magazine.
- <sup>14</sup> Joshua J. McElwee, “Francis: Christians Must Apologize to Gay People for Marginalizing Them,” *National Catholic Reporter*, June 26, 2016.
- <sup>15</sup> Voice of the Family, “Where Does Pope Francis Really Stand on Contraception?,” February 1, 2017, <https://voiceofthefamily.com>.
- <sup>16</sup> Kohlhaas, “Constructing Parenthood,” 617–635.